The Quantum Collective

Premium Membership Strategy — v3 (research-backed)

A members-only network for funded quantum builders · $300+/month · Built to plant the flag early in quantum

Prepared for Altivum Inc. · June 2026

What changed from v1 (and why this version is right)

The first draft treated this as a free, trust-first meetup. Your real vision is a **premium paid membership business** — $300+/month, positioned as exclusive, where the entire job is to deliver enough value (an elite peer network *plus* real resources and acceleration) that funded quantum founders happily pay. The goal is to grow, to enter the quantum market early while it's still nascent, and to earn the price through targeted recruiting and genuine value — not vibes.

This version is built around that economic reality. Every section answers one question: **does this justify $300+/month to a funded quantum founder?**

1. The thesis: why a premium quantum network works now

Premium founder networks are a proven, large business — and $300/mo is actually the value end of the market. The comparables:

Network	Price	Bar to enter
Hampton (Sam Parr)	~$8,500/yr (~$700/mo)	$3M+ revenue/funding, tech focus (Long Angle)
EO (Entrepreneurs' Org)	$6,000–$10,000/yr	$1M+ revenue (Long Angle)
YPO	$10,000+/yr	Large-company CEOs (Business Builder Camp)
Vistage	$10,000–$20,000/yr	Executives (Business Builder Camp)
The Quantum Collective	**$3,600/yr ($300/mo)**	**Funded quantum founders**

At $300/month you are **the most accessible premium founder network**, while still filtering out tire-kickers. That's the sweet spot: serious enough to be high-signal, affordable enough that a funded founder expenses it without a second thought.

Why the niche makes it defensible. Hampton and EO are horizontal — any tech founder. Quantum is a vertical so specialized that a generalist network can't serve it: the technical vocabulary, the capital structure (deep-tech, long timelines, grant-heavy), the customer profile (enterprise/government), and the talent pool are all distinct. A quantum-only network is something Hampton structurally can't replicate.

Why now — the early-market advantage. Quantum is consolidating into ~45 dense clusters that capture 96% of global funding (The Quantum Insider), and capital is flooding in — Maryland's $1B initiative, Illinois' $500M park, IBM Ventures' $500M into ~20 startups (Business Insider). The founder population is still small enough that you can *know everyone* — but it's growing fast. **Whoever becomes the default network for quantum founders now owns that position as the field 10x's.** That is the early-mover prize.

The ROI math that closes every sale. A single warm investor intro that leads to one check returns the fee many times over — at $3,600/yr, even one $100K intro is ~30x ROI (Capitaly.vc on Hampton). For deep-tech founders raising large rounds, the ROI framing is even stronger. This is your core sales argument.

2. Why this market is so prolific — and why a quantum hub now yields revenue

This section is the evidentiary backbone for the whole strategy. It answers three questions in sequence: (a) why founder-hub / paid-community businesses have exploded into a real category, (b) why tech-cluster communities reliably create outsized economic value, and (c) why doing this for quantum *right now* converts that pattern into revenue.

2.1 Why founder hubs and paid communities have become a prolific business category

The rise of paid communities is not a fad — it sits on top of two of the largest secular shifts in how business is done.

- **The membership / subscription economy is a multi-trillion-dollar shift.** The global subscription economy was worth roughly $650B in 2020 and is projected to exceed $1.5 trillion by 2030, growing at 15%+ annually, because recurring-revenue models built on community, peer influence, and network effects out-retain and out-grow one-time-transaction models (Advances in Consumer Research). Stanford GSB frames membership models as "the most disruptive shift in business since the Industrial Revolution" precisely because they convert customers into recurring, high-retention members (Stanford GSB).
- **The "passion / creator economy" made niche communities monetizable at scale.** The creator economy is projected to roughly double from ~$250B in 2023 to ~$480B by 2027 (Goldman Sachs), with later estimates reaching $528B by 2030 (SNS Insider). Critically for you, the data shows **depth beats breadth and expertise beats entertainment**: "knowledge creators" (educators, founders, consultants) earn ~3x more than lifestyle creators with the same audience size, and courses/newsletters/communities are the fastest-growing revenue channels (Matt Swain, LinkedIn analysis). A specialized, high-trust quantum network is exactly the high-value, knowledge-led niche this trend rewards.
- **Demand for niche, interest-based communities is structurally high.** Survey work cited by Forbes found that over 70% of people would join one or more community groups built around a personal passion or professional interest, and that platforms monetizing *interactions* (not attention) command rising subscription willingness as communities grow (Forbes).

The proven, profitable comparables in your exact niche (from Section 1) confirm the model works at premium prices: Hampton (~$8,500/yr), EO ($6–10K/yr), and YPO/Vistage ($10K+/yr) are durable, sought-after businesses (Long Angle, Business Builder Camp). The category is prolific because the unit economics are excellent: recurring revenue, low marginal cost per member, and retention that *compounds* as the network grows.

2.2 Why tech-cluster communities create outsized, capturable value

Founder hubs aren't just nice-to-have — decades of economics show that **co-locating founders and concentrating networks measurably accelerates company outcomes**, and that the organizer who curates that network captures real value.

- **Clusters are where modern innovation and value concentrate.** Harvard Business School's research on tech clusters finds that places like Silicon Valley play a central role in innovation and business competitiveness because density drives engineer mobility, knowledge flows, and shared inputs — the "agglomeration" effects that make the whole greater than the sum of its parts (Harvard Business School, *Tech Clusters*). Silicon Valley's resilience and growth have been attributed specifically to its dense professional networks, alliances, and face-to-face interaction — not just its companies (IDE economic-agglomeration study).
- **The accelerator model proves a curated network changes outcomes.** Y Combinator — the clearest proof that "being in the right room" is a growth multiplier — has helped create 90+ unicorns and over $600B in combined market value; its companies raise a Series A at 45% (vs. 33% baseline), become unicorns at ~4.5% (vs. 2.5%), and survive 10 years at >50% (vs. ~30%) (Lenny Rachitsky / YC data, Y Combinator). The lesson YC itself emphasizes: "access to the right network is a growth multiplier... being in the right rooms, getting early credibility, and attracting top talent before you even hit product-market fit." That is precisely the value The Quantum Collective sells.
- **Ecosystem value is large and measurable — and curators capture a share.** Startup Genome quantifies "ecosystem value" in the tens-to-hundreds of billions per region (Seoul went from $40B to $237B), and reports that ecosystems with dedicated ecosystem-building support grew value ~59% faster than peers (Startup Genome). The takeaway: deliberately building connective tissue around founders is a value-creating act, not overhead.

The through-line: networks of founders produce demonstrably better company outcomes, and the entity that organizes and curates the network — the hub — is positioned to monetize that value through membership, sponsorship, and events.

2.3 Why quantum, and why now, turns this into revenue

Applying the proven hub model to quantum *at this moment* is what creates the revenue opportunity, for four compounding reasons.

- **The underlying market is large and growing fast.** The quantum computing market is projected to grow from ~$3.5B in 2025 to ~$20B by 2030 at a ~42% CAGR (MarketsandMarkets), and analysts project quantum technologies could reach $97B by 2035 (McKinsey via

QuantumBasel), with $450–850B of cumulative economic value created by 2040 (BCG). A rising market means a steadily growing pool of fundable founders — your future members.

- **Capital is flooding into the founders you'd serve.** VC-backed quantum startups raised $1.9B across 62 rounds in 2024 — a 138% jump over 2023 — and the trend toward fewer-but-larger checks accelerated in 2025 (Crunchbase, QuantumBasel). Funded founders are exactly the members who can expense $300/mo without blinking, and the capital flow is the substrate for the deal-flow value you'll broker. Public commitments add fuel: global government quantum funding exceeded $10B by 2025 (QuantumBasel).
- **The early-mover position is uniquely capturable right now.** The founder population is still small enough that one organizer can credibly *know and convene most of it* — there were on the order of 76 major quantum companies as of 2026 plus a long tail of funded startups (The Quantum Insider, GrowthList funded-startup tracker). Because clusters now capture 96% of quantum funding (The Quantum Insider), the network is concentrated and reachable. **Whoever becomes the default hub before the field 10x's owns that position as it scales** — the same first-mover dynamic that made YC and the early Silicon Valley networks durable.
- **The revenue follows directly.** A growing, capital-rich, concentrated founder base + a proven premium-membership model + an early, uncontested category position = recurring dues, sponsorship from cloud platforms racing to win quantum developers (AWS, Azure, IBM are already investing heavily — e.g., AWS's Ocelot chip), and a flagship-event franchise. The market is large enough to sustain the business and nascent enough that you can own it.

Bottom line: Paid founder hubs are prolific because the membership economy is booming and curated founder networks demonstrably accelerate companies (YC, Silicon Valley, Startup Genome). Quantum supplies a large, fast-growing, capital-saturated, and still-small-enough-to-capture founder base. Building The Quantum Collective now applies a proven, profitable model to an under-served, high-value niche at the exact moment the category is forming — which is why it yields revenue.

3. How big is this, really? A bottom-up market size

The v1 draft hand-waved the addressable market. This section replaces that with a defensible, bottom-up estimate — and tells you the honest truth: **the funded-quantum-founder market is genuinely small, but unusually defensible.** Treat this as the financial reality check the whole plan must respect.

3.1 The funded-founder pool, counted from the bottom up

The building blocks, from primary industry sources:

- **Pure-play quantum startups globally:** ~367 (McKinsey 2024) to ~556 (QED-C 2026), depending on how "quantum" is defined (McKinsey Quantum Technology Monitor 2024, QED-C State of the Global Quantum Industry 2026).
- **Of those, venture-funded:** blending Crunchbase-derived counts (GrowthList tracks 281 funded QC startups) with a ~50–60% funded rate on the QED-C base yields a working estimate of **~280–350 globally venture-funded pure-play quantum startups**.

- **Founders per company:** quantum is overwhelmingly PhD-led — over 50% of core-quantum founders hold a PhD (vs. ~10% of startups generally) — which typically means 2–3 technical/commercial co-founders. Using ~2.5 and an 85% still-active haircut gives **~640–750 active founders globally.**

3.2 TAM / SAM / SOM

Tier	Definition	Founders	ARR at $3,600/yr
TAM	All founders of globally venture-funded pure-play quantum startups	**~750**	**~$2.7M**
SAM	English-speaking, reachable founders (US, Canada, UK, Australia)	**~400**	**~$1.44M**
SOM — Year 3, base (22% of SAM)	Realistic 3-year penetration	**~100 members**	**~$360K**

The US alone is ~100–120 funded quantum startups — roughly 30–41% of the global pool — concentrated in three clusters (Bay Area, Greater Washington/Maryland, Denver-Boulder) that hold more than half of global quantum startup funding (ECIPE / The Quantum Insider, McKinsey 2024). That concentration is good news: the people you want are reachable in a handful of cities and at a handful of events.

3.3 Three-year revenue scenarios (be honest about scale)

Scenario	Year-3 penetration of SAM	Members	Year-3 ARR
Conservative	10%	~45	~$162K
Base	22%	~100	~$360K
Optimistic	35%	~158	~$569K

The honest verdict: this is a **niche, highly defensible micro-business — roughly $200K–$570K ARR by Year 3 — not a venture-scale company.** Break-even at typical community costs ($50–80K/yr) needs only ~14–22 paying members, so it's profitable early, but the dues line alone has a hard ceiling in the hundreds-of-thousands until the field grows or the audience widens. Plan, staff, and fundraise (if at all) accordingly: this is a cash-generating flagship and platform, not a rocket ship.

3.4 Why small is acceptable here — and the levers to grow it

The smallness is partly the point: a community of 60–100 quantum founders covers a meaningful fraction of the entire global ecosystem — the "everyone-knows-everyone" density that makes the network sticky and the brand category-defining. And quantum founders already spend $3,000–$10,000/year on conferences, so $3,600/year is a comfortable, even modest, line item. Three deliberate levers expand the ceiling when you're ready:

1. **Widen from founders to top operators (the cleanest expansion).** Including the top 2–3 people at each funded company roughly triples the eligible pool to **~320–480 members**

while keeping the quantum brand intact.

2. **Add quantum-focused investors as a complementary segment** — there are 11+ dedicated quantum VC firms globally plus 50+ corporate VC arms; they're both members and a value-add to founders.
3. **Raise price to $600–$1,000/mo** for the same audience — defensible given conference spend and exclusivity, doubling or tripling ARR at the same penetration.

The tailwind is real: VC into quantum hit **$4.1B in 2025, up from $2.0B in 2024** (Crunchbase), and McKinsey declared a commercial tipping point in its 2026 monitor — but the *founder pool* will stay in the hundreds, not thousands, for the next 3–5 years. Build for that.

4. The competitive landscape — and why founders would pay vs. use free options

The single biggest unanswered question in v1 was: *with so many free quantum communities, accelerators, and consortia, why would a founder pay $300/mo?* This section answers it with a full landscape scan and a structural "why pay" argument.

4.1 What already exists (and what it isn't)

Founders today have four kinds of alternatives — none of which is a curated, paid, founders-only, ongoing quantum peer network:

- **Quantum consortia & ecosystem hubs** — QED-C, Elevate Quantum (Mountain West), Chicago Quantum Exchange, Le Lab Quantique (France). These are *ecosystem-builders* serving the whole supply chain — researchers, enterprises, labs, government, students — not confidential CEO-to-CEO peer groups. The founder is one stakeholder among many.
- **Quantum accelerators** — CDL Quantum, Duality/Alchemist Chicago, UMD Quantum Startup Foundry. Excellent but *time-limited and cohort-based* — they end, the cohort disperses, and they're gated by stage and geography.
- **Open / free communities** — Unitary Foundation (~5,500-member Discord), OneQuantum, QWorld, LinkedIn/Slack groups. These are *workforce, education, and developer* platforms — public, uncurated, no confidentiality. A founder can't discuss burn rate, a down round, or a churned customer there.
- **General premium founder networks** — Hampton (~$792/mo), EO ($500–833/mo), YPO ($833+/mo). These have the peer-accountability structure but are *horizontal* — a quantum founder's group might be a SaaS CEO, a real-estate operator, and a DTC brand. No quantum-specific capital network, grant literacy, or domain knowledge.
- **Conferences** — Q2B, IEEE Quantum Week, APS March Meeting. High-density but episodic (once a year), public, with no follow-up or confidentiality.

4.2 The precise white space

> **A recurring, curated, confidential peer network exclusively for actively operating quantum startup founders — with structured peer accountability, warm introductions to quantum-specialized investors, and ongoing domain-specific knowledge — sustained over years, not a one-time cohort.**

This is what Hampton does for tech founders horizontally and YPO does for mature CEOs — but applied *vertically* to quantum, with the deep-tech VC network, government-program literacy, and sub-sector peer knowledge only same-domain peers can provide. The closest analogs are biotech or climate-tech CEO peer groups — and **no equivalent exists in quantum today.**

4.3 The nine-attribute comparison

Attribute	Free Discord / Consortia	Quantum Accelerators	General Premium (Hampton/EO/YPO)	**The Quantum Collective**
Quantum-specific domain	✓	✓	✗	✓
Founders-only peer group	✗	Partial (cohort)	✓	✓
Ongoing (not time-limited)	✓	✗	✓	✓
Curated / selective	✗	✓	✓	✓
Confidential	✗	Partial	✓	✓
Structured peer accountability	✗	✗	✓	✓
Warm capital introductions	✗	Partial	Partial	✓
No equity / dilution	✓	✗ (some)	✓	✓
Accessible globally	✓	✗ (regional/cohort)	Partial	✓

The Quantum Collective is the **only** cell where all nine are present at once. Every other option has at least one critical gap (full landscape scan, Hampton, EO, YPO).

4.4 Why pay $300/mo when free options exist — five structural reasons

Crucially, **$300/mo is the lowest-cost premium peer community on the market** — cheaper than Hampton (~$792/mo), YPO ($833+/mo), and EO ($500–833/mo), and less than the cost of attending Q2B once with travel. The case for paying rests on five things free alternatives *structurally* cannot deliver:

1. **Curation creates the product.** Value comes from peer quality, not network size. Verified-founder gating gives a signal floor that open Discords and LinkedIn groups — diluted by students, vendors, and spectators — can never reach.

2. **Payment creates skin in the game and trust.** Paying members show up and reveal real information; the fee filters out free-riders, which is exactly what lets a CEO admit a co-founder dispute or a down round.
3. **Confidentiality is a feature you can't buy on free platforms.** Quantum is small and competitive; founders compete for the same customers and watch the same agencies. A confidential, norm-enforced room (Chatham House–style) enables conversations that are impossible in public channels.
4. **Warm capital intros have asymmetric value.** Quantum-specialized VCs (Quantonation, DCVC, Playground Global, In-Q-Tel, Airbus Ventures) are relationship-driven and hard to cold-approach. One warm intro that leads to a term sheet returns years of membership fees — and free communities have no structured intro mechanism.
5. **Peer accountability is a performance accelerator with no free equivalent.** Structured, recurring goal-setting with 8–10 domain peers — the proven EO/Hampton/Vistage mechanism — has no Discord or conference substitute, and it's far more valuable when the peers actually understand quantum milestones, grant cycles, and talent scarcity.

5. Who pays, who joins: resolving the audience

The earlier framing of "all quantum builders" and the pricing of "$300/mo for funded founders" describe two different products. This resolves the tension explicitly so the model is coherent.

The rule: the paid core is founders; the free ring is everyone else.

Group	Tier	Pays?	Why
Founders / co-founders of funded quantum startups	The Collective (paid core)	$300/mo	Budget (expensable), acute need (capital, customers, hiring), highest willingness to pay for peer trust and warm intros.
Pre-funded / aspiring founders	Free or low-cost on-ramp	Mostly free	High future value, low current budget. Nurture them; convert when they raise.
Engineers, researchers, students, operators	The Signal (free outer ring)	Free	They create the liveliness, talent pipeline, and content gravity — but won't pay $300/mo and shouldn't be asked to.
Investors, ecosystem allies	Invite / partner	Varies	Valuable to the network but not the paying base; they're part of the value *delivered* to founders.

Why this resolution is right: a community needs the energy builders bring, but a *business* needs payers who get acute ROI. Builders in the free ring make the founders' paid experience richer (talent to hire, ideas to mine, a stage to speak on) — so the free tier is not charity, it's the substrate that makes the paid tier worth $300/mo. This means **"all quantum builders" stays true at the community level, while "funded founders" is true at the revenue level.**

6. Positioning & the promise

Positioning statement:

> The Quantum Collective is the private, members-only network for funded quantum founders — the room where the people building the quantum economy share deal flow, hard-won lessons, and warm access to capital, customers, and talent that exists nowhere else.

The membership promise (what $300/mo buys): Two things, deliberately — because you said the value is *elite peer network* AND *resources & acceleration*.

1. **The room.** A vetted, founders-only network of the most credible quantum builders — peers, relationships, status, and warm intros. You can't buy your way to these people cold.
2. **The acceleration.** Concrete resources that move companies forward: curated capital access, expert office hours, technical-and-commercial playbooks, partner credits, and high-signal programming.

The retention insight (this is what makes the business durable): Content gets people to *join*; community is what makes them *stay* (PeepSo). Value must flow *between members*, not just from you to them. So the product is engineered around member-to-member interaction — curated peer groups, intros, and an active channel — not a course library that goes stale. Hampton's own data shows the value compounds: the longer you're in, the more intros and insight the network returns (Capitaly.vc).

7. The tiered model

You chose tiered: a free/cheap outer ring as a funnel, with the $300+/mo inner circle as the real product. Three layers:

Tier 1 — The Signal (free outer ring · the funnel)

- **Who:** Any quantum builder — founders, engineers, researchers, students.
- **What they get:** The newsletter, public webinars, open community channel, and ecosystem content.
- **Purpose:** Top-of-funnel. This is your marketing engine and your applicant pool. It grows the community broadly (your stated goal) while protecting the premium core. It costs you almost nothing and feeds everything.

Tier 2 — The Round (premium inner circle · $300+/mo · the product)

- **Who:** Funded quantum founders (your first and primary buyer), accepted by application.
- **What they get:** Everything in the value stack below — curated peer groups, warm capital intros, expert office hours, member directory, private high-signal channel, members-only events, and partner perks.
- **Purpose:** The revenue engine and the reason the whole thing exists.

Tier 3 — Patrons & Partners (sponsors)

- **Who:** Cloud quantum platforms (AWS Braket, Azure Quantum, IBM Quantum), deep-tech VCs, IP/law firms, hardware vendors, economic-development orgs.
- **What they get:** Credible access, brand association, sponsored programming — never seats in the core peer groups.
- **Purpose:** Non-dues revenue that subsidizes member value and improves your margin (a core lever in premium-community economics — GrowthZone).

Optional 4th lever — annual founding-member upsell: A higher tier (e.g., $5–8K/yr) for founders who want curated mastermind cohorts and priority intros — mirrors how Hampton/EO price by stage. Introduce only after the $300 tier is proven.

8. The value stack — exactly what justifies $300+/month

This is the heart of the rewrite. Each item is a concrete deliverable, grouped by the two promises.

A. Elite peer network

- **Curated peer groups (the core).** Members placed into small, confidential mastermind circles of 6–10 by stage and modality (hardware / software / sensing / networking / post-quantum). Recurring, facilitated, structured turns. This is the single most valuable and most defensible element — it's the Hampton model, applied to quantum.
- **Vetted member directory.** Searchable by company, modality, stage, cluster — so a member can find "the only other founder solving cryogenic control" in minutes.
- **High-signal private channel.** Active Slack/Discord with enforced no-spam, no-vendor-pitch norms. The reason members open the app daily.
- **Members-only events + an annual flagship summit** timed to the conference circuit (IEEE Quantum Week, Q2B, APS March Meeting) so scattered founders convene where they already travel (QuEra conference guide).

B. Resources & acceleration

- **Curated capital access.** The headline ROI driver. Warm intros to deep-tech and quantum-focused investors, a periodic member-only "investor day," and shared fundraising intelligence (who's writing checks, timing, terms). One intro pays for years of membership.
- **Expert office hours.** Recurring sessions with quantum-fluent specialists members otherwise can't easily reach: deep-tech VCs, IP/patent attorneys (critical in quantum), enterprise/government BD experts, and cloud architects. Your AWS Braket fluency makes you credible to curate the technical side.
- **The Quantum Operator's Library.** Living, member-only playbooks: raising a deep-tech round, structuring SBIR/grant funding, selling quantum pilots to enterprises, hiring scarce quantum talent. Documented from real member experience (the "document what you're actually doing" discipline — Clay Banks on LinkedIn).

- **Partner perks & credits.** Negotiated cloud credits (Braket/Azure/IBM), legal/IP discounts, tooling deals. Tangible dollar value members can point to — helps the $300 feel like net-positive on day one.
- **Customer & pilot access.** Over time, curated intros to enterprise/government buyers running quantum pilots — the hardest thing for a quantum founder to source alone.

The "ROI receipt" tactic: Quantify the stack on your sales page — e.g., cloud credits + legal discount + one office-hours session already exceed the annual fee in hard dollars, before a single intro. Makes the price a no-brainer.

9. The cold-start problem: what's real at launch vs. earned over time

At $300/mo the value-stack promises are large — warm investor intros, enterprise pilot access, expert office hours. Honesty: **on day one, as a solo founder, you cannot fully deliver most of these.** A network has no intros until it has members; a community has no signal until it has activity. Pretending otherwise will burn early trust. Here's the realistic ramp.

Promise	Deliverable at launch (Month 0–3)	Earned by scale (Month 6–18)
Elite peer network	YOU + a hand-picked founding cohort (the room is small but real and high-quality)	Multiple cohorts, deep directory, daily-active channel
Warm capital intros	Your personal network + 1–2 friendly investors you recruit as "founding patrons"	A repeatable investor-day and a roster of participating VCs
Expert office hours	1–2 sessions you personally arrange (IP attorney, a quantum VC you know)	A standing roster of recurring experts
Resources / playbooks	A starter Operator's Library you write from your own AWS-quantum experience	A living library co-authored by members
Partner perks / credits	Pursue one cloud-credit deal (you have AWS-quantum credibility to land it)	Multiple negotiated vendor deals
Customer / pilot access	Honestly, not yet — set expectations	Curated enterprise/government pilot intros as the network matures

How to bootstrap credibility before the network exists (solving cold-start):

- **Lead with what you can deliver now:** an exceptional founding cohort + a few real expert sessions + your own hard-won playbooks. Under-promise, over-deliver.
- **Use founding-member pricing to make the early bet fair:** a locked-in lower rate (or free first 60–90 days) acknowledges that early members are helping you build the network they're paying for.
- **Recruit 1–2 anchor assets first:** one credible investor and one respected senior founder as "founding patrons" instantly make the room worth joining.
- **Manufacture the first proof points:** engineer one visible win in the first 90 days (a real intro that lands, a pilot conversation, a standout session) and tell that story.

10. Go-to-market: targeted advertising & acquisition

You named this directly — the implied task is to attract the right people through targeted advertising and real value. Here's the funnel, top to bottom.

The funnel shape: Free Signal tier (broad reach) → application → vetting → paid Round membership. Premium communities convert by deterring tire-kickers with an application/vetting step, not by mass sign-ups (Capitaly.vc).

Targeted acquisition channels (in priority order)

1. **Founder-led, hand-picked recruiting (highest-converting, do first).** The first 20–30 members can't come from ads — they come from you personally inviting credible founders. Your AWS Builder Center presence and quantum-on-AWS work put you one or two intros from many of them.
2. **The free tier as a paid-acquisition target.** Run targeted ads (LinkedIn especially — you can target by title "Founder/CEO" + industry/skill "quantum computing," and by following quantum orgs) driving to the *free Signal tier and webinars,* not directly to the $300 ask. Warm them with value, then convert. This keeps CAC sane.
3. **Conference hand-to-hand.** The quantum founder population is concentrated at a handful of events; recruit in the hallway track at IEEE Quantum Week, Q2B, APS March Meeting (QuEra).
4. **Ecosystem partnerships for sourcing.** Co-market with QED-C, Elevate Quantum, university quantum centers (Chicago Quantum Exchange, UMD Quantum Startup Foundry). They have the founders; you have the premium network they don't offer (QED-C, Elevate Quantum).
5. **Content-led inbound.** The newsletter + anonymized "what quantum founders are wrestling with" digests + member spotlights. Slow-build, but it's the compounding, low-CAC channel that makes you the category's voice.
6. **Member referrals (your best channel once running).** Each member nominates peers. Curated referral keeps signal high and CAC near zero.

Targeting message (what the ad/landing page says)

- Lead with the ROI and exclusivity, not features: "The private network for funded quantum founders. One intro pays for the year."
- Use scarcity honestly: small, vetted, application-only.
- Always route cold traffic to a free, value-first entry point (webinar or newsletter), never straight to the paywall.

11. Unit economics & growth math

Premium-community economics are attractive because dues are recurring and marginal cost per member is low. Illustrative math at $300/mo ($3,600/yr) — read alongside the bottom-up market size in Section 3, which caps realistic Year-3 membership near ~100:

Members	Annual dues revenue	+ Sponsorship (illustrative)	Notes
25	$90,000	$25–50K	Founding cohort; proves the model
50	$180,000	$50–100K	Sustainable solo/small-team operation
100	$360,000	$100K+	Real business; hire ops + programming
250	$900,000	$200K+	Category-defining network

Key levers:

- **Retention is everything.** A premium community lives or dies on renewal. Member-to-member value and compounding intros are what drive it (PeepSo, Capitaly.vc). Track returning-member rate above all vanity metrics.
- **Non-dues revenue widens margin.** Sponsorship lets you over-deliver value without raising dues — a deliberate strategy in mature membership orgs (GrowthZone). A single annual cloud-platform partner can fund your events and tooling.
- **Keep the offer simple.** 2–4 tiers max; complexity kills conversion (ManageMemberships).
- **Costs stay lean early.** Borrowed/sponsor venues, off-the-shelf tools (community platform, Luma, newsletter), and your time. The main investment is programming quality and your network.

The nascent-market reality (set expectations): Per Section 3, the funded-quantum-founder SAM is ~400 and realistic Year-3 membership is ~45–158 (base ~100). The 250-member row above is only reachable if you widen to operators/investors or raise price. That smallness is a feature: 50–100 members is a *genuinely dominant* share of the global ecosystem. Price for value (premium), not volume, until the field grows into you.

12. The early-market phasing plan

Because quantum is nascent, sequence the build so you capture the position now without over-investing ahead of the market.

Phase 1 — Plant the flag (Months 0–3): Prove the premium core

- Lock name, positioning, and the value stack.
- Hand-recruit a **founding cohort of 15–25 funded quantum founders.** Offer founding-member terms (e.g., locked-in rate, founding badge) to reward early belief.
- Run the first curated peer groups + one excellent office-hours session. Over-deliver.
- Launch the free Signal tier + newsletter as the funnel.
- **Goal:** A paying core that renews and refers. This validates that founders will pay $300+/mo.

Phase 2 — Build the engine (Months 3–9): Make value undeniable

- Systematize the value stack: recurring peer groups, monthly office hours, the Operator's Library, partner credits.
- Land the first sponsor (start with a cloud quantum platform — the most natural fit).
- Turn on targeted LinkedIn acquisition into the free tier; build the application funnel.
- Host the first members-only event tied to a conference.
- **Goal:** 50 members, proven retention, one sponsor, a repeatable acquisition motion.

Phase 3 — Scale the position (Months 9–24): Become the default

- Expand to multiple peer-group cohorts; add the annual flagship summit.
- Introduce the higher-priced founding/mastermind tier if demand supports it.
- Deepen ecosystem partnerships (QED-C, Elevate Quantum, university centers) for sourcing and credibility.
- **Goal:** 100+ members, multiple sponsors, recognized as *the* quantum founder network — so as the field 10x's, you own the category.

13. Success metrics & kill criteria

Decide in advance what "working" looks like — and what would tell you to stop.

Leading indicators (track weekly/monthly):

- Founding-cohort attendance and channel activity (are people showing up and posting?)
- Number of member-to-member intros made
- Hot-seat problems surfaced and resolved
- Net Promoter / "would you recommend" from members

Lagging indicators (track quarterly):

- Paid member count and month-over-month growth
- Net revenue retention / renewal rate (the single most important number for a subscription community)
- Member-sourced referrals (a healthy community recruits itself)
- Sponsorship revenue secured

Milestone targets (adjust to your ambition):

- Month 3: 15–25 paying (or founding-rate) members; >70% of Round Zero attendees commit to return.
- Month 6: 30–40 members; renewal intent >80%; first sponsor conversation live.
- Month 12: 50+ members; demonstrated retention; one signed sponsor; one flagship event held.

Kill / pivot criteria (be disciplined):

- If, after an excellent pilot, fewer than ~half of founding members will pay or renew → the willingness-to-pay isn't there at $300/mo; pivot price, audience, or model.
- If member-to-member value isn't forming (you're the only one giving value) → the network effect isn't igniting; rethink curation or composition.
- If you can't reach ~30 paying members within 9–12 months given the addressable pool (Section 3) → revisit TAM assumptions and whether to broaden audience or raise price.

14. Risks & mitigations (premium-specific)

Risk	Mitigation
TAM too small today	Embrace it — aim to own most of a small market; price for value not volume; broaden the free tier to grow with the field.
Can't justify $300 in month one	Front-load the "ROI receipt" — partner credits + office hours + one intro that exceed the fee immediately; founding-rate to de-risk early joiners.
Churn after the novelty fades	Engineer member-to-member value (peer groups, intros, active channel) so the product improves with participation, not just your content.
Looks like another Slack/Discord	Vetting, exclusivity, and curated intros are the moat — sell the *room and the access*, not a chat app.
CAC too high from cold ads	Never advertise straight to the paywall; route ads to free value, convert warm. Lean on referrals and founder-led recruiting.
Competes with QED-C / Elevate / accelerators	Complement, don't compete — you're the premium peer + capital-access layer they don't offer; partner for sourcing.
Solo-founder bandwidth	Sponsor revenue funds an ops hire by ~50 members; delegate facilitation early.

15. Your unfair advantage (founder–market fit)

A strategy is only as good as the person executing it. Your background is a genuine moat for this specific business — it should be stated, not hidden:

- **Veteran (Green Beret) founder:** trust, discipline, and mission-credibility — and a natural bridge to the well-funded veteran-in-deep-tech and national-security-quantum communities (a real, fundable niche given defense interest in quantum).
- **Technical credibility in quantum-on-AWS:** you speak the founders' language (qubits, Braket, error correction) AND the cloud-architecture language sponsors care about — rare in a community organizer, and exactly what lets you curate credible technical programming and land a cloud sponsor.
- **AWS Builder Center presence + content practice:** an existing distribution surface and the documentation habit that fuels the content engine.
- **Altivum as the operating entity:** a credible corporate home that signals you're building infrastructure, not a hobby.

This combination — military trust + quantum-technical depth + cloud-sponsor fluency + a content platform — is hard to replicate and is the reason you, specifically, can build this.

16. Legal, structure & operating questions to resolve

At $300/mo handling money, intros, and confidential founder information, a few things need decisions before launch:

- **Entity & structure:** Run it under Altivum, spin up a dedicated LLC, or pursue non-profit / fiscal sponsorship (which can unlock ecosystem and government quantum grants and signals infrastructure over lead-gen). Defer the non-profit decision until after the pilot, but pick a billing entity now.
- **Confidentiality agreement:** A short, plain-language member agreement — the product depends on it. Required at join.
- **Investor-intro conduct:** Decide your stance on broker-dealer / finders'-fee rules — make intros as a community service, not for transaction-based compensation, to stay clear of securities-intermediary regulations. (Get brief legal advice here.)
- **Payments & subscriptions:** A billing platform (Stripe-based community tooling) and a clear refund / cancellation policy.
- **Data & privacy:** Member directory consent and handling of confidential company information shared in sessions.

17. Decisions to greenlight the rewrite into execution

1. **Confirm price & tier structure** — $300/mo inner circle, free Signal funnel, sponsor tier. Adjust the number if you want to test $300 vs. $400 vs. a $3,600 annual.
2. **Confirm the value stack** (Section 8) — which elements are must-have at launch vs. phase-2.
3. **Approve the founding-cohort approach** — locked-in founding rate to reward the first 15–25.
4. **Name — locked: The Quantum Collective.** (Action: verify domain/handles availability and trademark clearance.)
5. **Greenlight the founding-member target list** so I can research 25–30 specific funded quantum founders to invite first.

What I can build next, fast: (a) a researched target list of 25–30 funded quantum founders with intro angles; (b) a premium landing page with the ROI-receipt value stack and an application form; (c) a one-page sponsorship deck for cloud platforms; (d) the member application + vetting rubric; (e) a LinkedIn ad + targeting plan for the free-tier funnel.

Sources: premium founder-network pricing and ROI — Long Angle (EO vs. Hampton), Capitaly.vc on Hampton, Hampton, Business Builder Camp; membership / subscription / creator economy — Advances in Consumer Research (subscription economy), Stanford GSB (membership economy), Goldman Sachs (creator economy), SNS Insider, Forbes (passion economy), Matt Swain creator stats; tech clusters & accelerators — Harvard Business School (Tech Clusters), IDE agglomeration study, Y Combinator, Lenny Rachitsky / YC data, Startup Genome; membership-model and pricing strategy — PeepSo, GrowthZone, ManageMemberships, *Mighty Networks; quantum market & funding — The Quantum Insider (clusters), The Quantum Insider (top companies), MarketsandMarkets, BCG, QuantumBasel (investment stats), Crunchbase (quantum VC), GrowthList (funded startups), Business Insider; ecosystem orgs and events — QED-C, Elevate Quantum, QuEra; content discipline — Clay Banks on LinkedIn; market-size / TAM (Section 3) — McKinsey Quantum Technology Monitor 2024, McKinsey Quantum Monitor 2025, McKinsey Quantum Monitor 2026, QED-C State of the Global Quantum Industry 2026, QED-C market doubling, OECD/EPO Mapping the Global Quantum Ecosystem, Crunchbase 2026 (quantum investment), Steve Suarez / LinkedIn (QC startup count), 11+ quantum VC firms / LinkedIn; competitive landscape (Section 4) — QED-C, Unitary Foundation, OneQuantum, QWorld, Le Lab Quantique, Chicago Quantum Exchange, Elevate Quantum, CDL Quantum, Duality / Alchemist Chicago, UMD Quantum Startup Foundry, IBM Quantum Network, AWS Activate, Hampton, EO, YPO, Pavilion, Q2B, IEEE Quantum Week.*